Kulandaivelan—are a case in point. Gurunathaiyar, a police detective turned Swadeshi agitator, was an asset; though inducted as 'cargo superintendent' he was really VOC's man Friday. In addition to probably giving insights into how the police and administration worked, Gurunathaiyar was personal assistant, family friend and political lieutenant. Such committed people apart, VOC showed alacrity in hiring a capable journalist, Thiruvariyan Pillai to draft the founding documents; that he filed good stories in various national dailies was a bonus. However, hiring Thambusami Pillai who proved to be a turncoat and became a witness for the prosecution was a mistake.

Though we know little about how the dedicated S.D. Krishna Aiyangar and K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar were recruited, their commitment to the company in the most crises-ridden situations was surely a tribute to VOC's work. Why would they stake their all if they did not respect VOC? Their response to the company's collapse—the anger at its strangulation and the depressed mood—attests to their personal commitment and emotional investment.

VOC's extensive tours for fundraising apart he spent a considerable time in Bombay and Colombo. In Bombay, where he spent many months, VOC handled the tricky business of engaging with shipping magnates, shipbuilders, stevedores, agents, brokers and others. VOC could have himself gone to Europe to purchase the steamers. Aware of his own limitations, he deputed S. Vedamurthi Mudaliar for this task. Whether the steamers, the *Gallia* and the *Lawoe*, were overpriced or met industry standards will never be known. No doubt, the indifferent steamers brought the company to grief. VOC could hardly be blamed if he failed to find professionals with the right technical skills. International merchant shipping was a high stakes game, and perhaps VOC, and SSNCo, were short-changed. With big money and many middlemen involved, international shipping must have been tricky to navigate, especially for a neophyte like VOC. We will never know if he fell prey to deceptions; all that we know is that his successors travelled the same path and never complained about him. That he won the trust of shipping professionals is attested to by his